

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN CÔTE D'IVOIRE

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the forests, land, and rivers of Côte d'Ivoire — and here the destructive force has an unusual shape, because the great harm is not one project but a commodity, and the lever that can reach it runs through the world's chocolate. Côte d'Ivoire is by far the world's largest producer of cocoa, and cocoa is the leading cause of its deforestation: the country has lost the great majority of its natural forests in half a century, more than two million hectares of it cleared for cocoa in just the last two decades, endangered trees and elephants and chimpanzees vanishing with the forest, and cocoa planted illegally deep inside the classified forests and the national parks that were meant to be protected. At current rates, the forest cover could be all but entirely gone within a decade. This guide will be honest that much of this destruction is driven by poor farmers seeking fertile ground, that the government's response has sometimes meant evicting thousands of them, that the great chocolate companies' promises have too often gone unkept, and that there is no landmark community victory to point to; but it will show that the levers here, running through the supply chain and the forest law, are real.

The Ivorian story teaches two things about opposing destructive projects here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Ivorian, and it is what gives this guide its real force. **Because the destruction is driven by a commodity sold to the world — cocoa that becomes Europe's chocolate — the levers that reach it run through the supply chain: the traders and chocolate companies bound by their own promises and now by law, the certification and satellite monitoring that expose deforestation, the new import rules that bar deforestation-linked cocoa from wealthy markets, and the forest governance and livelihoods that can stop the frontier from moving.** That combination — the buyers and their commitments, the import regulation, the monitoring, the forest law, and deforestation-free livelihoods — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because a harm that flows out through the world's chocolate can be pressed back through it.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The obstacle here is bound up with poverty and justice, not simple villainy.** Much of the deforestation is done by poor smallholder and migrant farmers who clear forest because virgin soil grows the best cocoa and because low prices push them to expand; and the state's enforcement has sometimes meant evicting thousands of such farmers from protected forests, which raises real human-rights concerns of its own, in a country still carrying the scars of civil conflict and sensitive disputes over land and belonging. This guide does not pretend the choices are simple, or that the forest can be saved by punishing the poor. What it shows is how, in a country whose destructive commodity is sold to a watching world, a community can use the supply chain, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and above all deforestation-free livelihoods to defend the forest without abandoning the farmers — holding both the forest and the people who live from it.

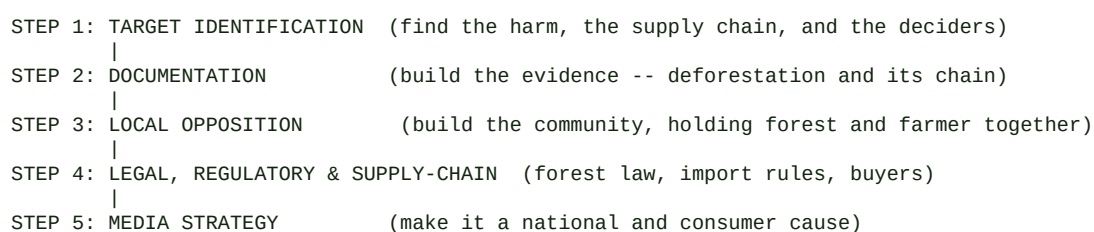
Most communities do not know HOW to use the levers a globally-traded commodity offers. They see the forest fall to cocoa, the parks invaded, the loggers at work, and either accept it as the price of survival or protest in ways that pit forest against farmer — and rarely reach the buyers bound by their promises, the

import rules that could bar deforestation-linked cocoa, the monitoring that could expose it, or the livelihood programmes that could stop the clearing. The gap between the forest defended and the forest lost is here often a gap of method — the method of using the supply chain, the law, the monitoring, and livelihoods together, and of holding forest and farmer together rather than against each other.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Ivorian reality as it is, which is a functioning if imperfect democracy whose harm is sold to the world. It is written for the person who sees the forest and its wildlife falling to cocoa, the parks invaded, the rivers silting — and who wants to know what can be done in a country where the destruction is a commodity and the poor are both its agents and its victims. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the supply chain, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and livelihoods — with the honest qualifiers that the forest is already largely gone, the companies' promises have gone unkept, the enforcement has harmed poor farmers, and there is no landmark victory to promise, only real levers and the hard work of defending both the forest and the people. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used. It is for the person willing to do the patient, two-sided work of defending the forest while lifting the farmers — tracing the cocoa, pressing the distant buyers, building deforestation-free livelihoods, and refusing the false choice between the trees and the poor — rather than the simpler and more satisfying work of finding a villain to denounce. That is not a softer form of action but, in Côte d'Ivoire's conditions, the only effective and the only just one, because here the villain, if there is one, is a whole system of poverty and distant profit rather than a single culprit, and the solution requires helping the poor as much as pressing the powerful. Anyone hoping simply to stop the farmers should understand that doing so is both unjust and futile, and that the real, durable defence of the forest runs through the supply chain and through the farmers' own better livelihoods. This guide is an honest map of that harder, two-sided path — the path of saving the forest and the farmers together.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to defend a classified forest, a national park, or a watershed from cocoa-driven clearing:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of deforestation and its supply chain feeds the buyers, the import regulators, the forest authorities, and the public at once; the community organises, holding forest and farmer together; a report to a buyer, an alert to an import regulator, or a livelihoods project is both pressure and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still difficult — chance of defending the forest without abandoning the farmers.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Côte d'Ivoire's — a destructive commodity sold to regulated markets, a monitored supply chain, forest governance, and a farming population that can be given alternatives — give communities a distinctive set:

- **The buyers and their commitments.** The **traders and chocolate companies** that buy Ivorian cocoa have made **zero-deforestation commitments** they can be held to.
- **The import regulation.** The **new rules barring deforestation-linked cocoa from wealthy markets** are a powerful, growing lever on the whole chain.
- **The monitoring and certification.** **Satellite monitoring, supply-chain mapping, and certification** can expose deforestation and trace it to its buyers.
- **The forest law and governance.** The **forest law, the classified forests and parks, and the reforestation policy** are domestic levers, if imperfectly enforced.
- **Deforestation-free livelihoods.** **Agroforestry, fair prices, and alternatives** can stop the frontier from moving — the deepest lever of all.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that the forest is easily saved. There is **no landmark win**; the forest is **largely gone**; the companies' promises have **too often gone unkept**; the enforcement has **harmed poor farmers**; and the deforestation is **driven by poverty**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it insists on holding forest and farmer together — and shows how to use the real, distinctive tools this situation offers — the supply chain, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and livelihoods — to defend the forest justly, honestly acknowledging the poverty, the broken promises, and the absence of a landmark victory.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must trace the harm along a chain that runs from a forest in Côte d'Ivoire to a chocolate bar in Europe. Before you spend a single week, map who and what actually drive the deforestation, at which link in the chain, and where the leverage is real. And map where the supply chain, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and livelihoods apply, because in Côte d'Ivoire deforestation is best met not by pitting forest against farmer, but by following the cocoa to its buyers and its markets, using the forest law, and giving farmers a way to live without clearing the forest.

The Levels of Decision and the Chain

Ivorian deforestation runs along a chain, from the forest to the world, and each link is a place to intervene.

The farmers and the frontier. At the source are the **smallholder and migrant farmers** who clear forest for cocoa — often poor, often driven by low prices and exhausted soil — whose need must be met, not merely punished.

The traders and buyers. The **cocoa traders and the chocolate companies** buy the cocoa and carry it to the world, and are bound by their **own zero-deforestation commitments** and, increasingly, by law — a decisive link in the chain.

The import markets and regulators. The **wealthy markets and their import rules** — now barring deforestation-linked cocoa — are a powerful lever on the whole chain, reachable through the regulators who enforce them.

The forest authorities and the state. The **forest agency, the forest law, the classified forests and parks, and the reforestation policy** are the domestic levers — imperfectly enforced, but real.

The monitors and civil society. The **satellite monitors, supply-chain mappers, certifiers, and civil-society watchdogs** expose the deforestation and trace it to its buyers, and are the community's allies across the chain.

The Journey of the Harm

Ivorian deforestation moves from a farmer clearing forest, through a trader buying the cocoa, to a chocolate company and a consumer market — with the **community's evidence, the buyers' commitments, the import rules, the forest law, the monitoring, and livelihoods** able to intervene at each link. **The buyers and the import rules are where the chain is most reachable, and livelihoods are where the frontier is stopped** — and using them together is the distinctive Ivorian approach. The distinctive levers are the **buyers, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and livelihoods**. Find out exactly where the deforestation happens and where its cocoa goes, and, crucially, **what forest is being lost, which traders and companies buy the cocoa from it, and how the import rules, the forest law, and livelihoods can be engaged**, because those are where the harm can be met.

Follow the Cocoa, the Forest, and the Buyers

Behind the deforestation stand the farmers, the traders, the companies, and the markets. Trace who clears, who buys, who profits, and — importantly here — **what forest and wildlife are lost, which traders and chocolate companies the cocoa flows to, how the import rules and forest law apply, and how farmers can be given deforestation-free livelihoods**. Two questions unlock most Ivorian efforts: **What forest is being lost, and whose cocoa is it?** and **Which lever — the buyers, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, livelihoods — can meet it?** The buyers, the import rules, and livelihoods are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in an Ivorian effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to trace the cocoa to its buyers and prove the loss; the community organising exists to unite forest and farmer behind livelihoods; and the media exists to connect the harm to the world's chocolate and the buyers who answer for it. Keep the buyers, the import rules, and livelihoods at the centre of every trace, filing, and project, and the effort retains a clear spine that runs from a single Ivorian forest to the world's markets and back, and that holds forest and farmer together throughout.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape the harm, because they are the community's levers. The **cocoa traders and chocolate companies** and their commitments; the **import markets and their regulators**; the **forest agency, the forest law, and the parks**; the **satellite monitors, supply-chain mappers, and certifiers**; the **civil-society watchdogs** that track cocoa and forests; and the **farmers and communities** at the frontier. In Côte d'Ivoire, the **buyers, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and livelihoods** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate link, and deforestation whose loss and supply chain are documented, pressed at the buyers and the import rules, met through the forest law and livelihoods, can genuinely be reduced and the frontier slowed — though, honestly, the forest is largely gone, the promises have been broken, and the poverty is real, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep holding forest and farmer together.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that much forest is already lost, that the companies' promises have often gone unkept, and that the deepest fix is the slow one of livelihoods. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how cocoa-and-forest

conflicts tend to go in Côte d'Ivoire and comparable commodity frontiers, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the community can **document the deforestation and trace its cocoa to the buyers**, whether it can **use the import rules, the monitoring, and the forest law**, and whether it can **give farmers deforestation-free livelihoods**. Where the harm is provable and the supply chain is traced, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the forest is largely gone, the promises are often broken, and the poverty that drives the clearing is real.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	10–20%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Deforestation-and-cha in case	35–55%	weeks–months	low	The loss and its buyers, established
Buyer / company pressure	35–55%	months	low–moderate	A trader or company pressed to act
Import-regulation route	40–60%	months–years	low	Deforestation-linked cocoa barred/excluded
Monitoring & certification	40–60%	months	low	Deforestation exposed and traced
Forest law & governance	30–50%	months–years	low–moderate	A forest defended, a concession challenged
Livelihoods (deforestation-free)	45–65%	years	moderate	The frontier stopped; farmers sustained
All levers together	40–60%	months–years	moderate	Frontier slowed, chain cleaned, forest held

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Côte d'Ivoire's real strengths are the supply-chain levers and livelihoods: the **buyers**, the **import rules**, the **monitoring**, the **forest law**, and **livelihoods**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the forest is **largely gone**, the companies' promises are **often unkept**, the enforcement has **harmed poor farmers**, and the clearing is **driven by poverty** — so progress comes through cleaning the chain and giving farmers alternatives, not through punishing the poor.

*A note on cost: the levers here — a documented case, a report to a buyer, an alert to an import regulator, a certification, a livelihoods project — cost mainly organisation and knowledge, though livelihoods programmes need funding, which the buyers, the reforestation policy, and international partners can supply. The scarce resources are **organisation, supply-chain evidence, and livelihoods funding** — much of it reachable through the buyers, the certifiers, and the international partners. This shapes where an Ivorian effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are the organisation to unite forest-defenders and farmers, the evidence to trace the supply chain, and the funding to build deforestation-free livelihoods — rather than the sheer numbers or confrontational force that other fights might require — a community's most valuable investments are in building a rigorous supply-chain trace, in connecting to the watchdogs and certifiers who can amplify it, and in reaching the buyers, programmes, and partners who can fund livelihoods. A small, well-organised community that can trace its forest's cocoa to a named buyer and propose a fundable livelihoods plan can accomplish far more than a large one that simply protests the clearing. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of evidence, connection, and funding for livelihoods — all of which are within a determined and well-networked community's reach. And because poverty drives the clearing, funding deforestation-free livelihoods is not a side task but the heart of the work.*

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (deforestation reduced, chain cleaned, frontier stopped)

PROVABLE HARM + TRACED CHAIN + IMPORT RULES + LIVELIHOODS:
Livelihoods (deforestation-free): ██████████ 45-65%
Import-regulation route: ██████████ 40-60%
Monitoring & certification: ██████████ 40-60%
All levers together: ██████████ 40-60%
Single lever: █████ 10-65%

FOREST LARGELY GONE / PROMISES BROKEN -- harder ground:
Punishing farmers alone: █████ can harm, rarely helps
Livelihoods funded / frontier held: ██████████ often achievable
Cleaning the chain / partial: ██████████ often achievable
The record / the case made: ██████████ more reliable than a stop

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Côte d'Ivoire are **livelihoods, the import rules, the monitoring, and the buyers** — used together, and holding forest and farmer together. The import rules and deforestation-free livelihoods show the ceiling: a cleaned supply chain and a sustained farmer can genuinely stop the frontier and protect the remaining forest. The largely-lost forest and the broken promises show the honest floor: much is already gone, and companies resist real change. Punishing farmers alone, the visualization warns, can do harm and rarely helps. Most Ivorian efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to clean the chain, defend the remaining forest, and stop the frontier — but that a landmark stop is unlikely, the poverty is real, and the deepest work is the slow one of livelihoods.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Deforestation-free livelihoods** — Côte d'Ivoire's deepest lever; the only thing that truly stops the frontier, and the just one.
2. **The import rules and the buyers** — the distinctive supply-chain levers that reach the whole chain.
3. **The monitoring and certification** — the evidence that exposes deforestation and traces it to its buyers.
4. **The forest law and governance** — the domestic levers, if imperfectly enforced.
5. **The deforestation-and-chain case** — the provable loss and the cocoa's path to the world.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **Livelihoods stop the frontier** — farmers given deforestation-free income and fair prices stop clearing; punishment alone does not. **The supply chain is reachable** — the buyers and the import rules are real, growing levers. **The monitoring works** — satellites and supply-chain maps can expose and trace deforestation. **Promises are broken** — the companies' commitments have too often gone unkept, so pressure and law are needed. **Punishing farmers backfires** — evictions harm the poor and drive clearing elsewhere. The through-line: **document the deforestation and trace its cocoa; press the buyers and the import rules; use the monitoring and the forest law; and above all give farmers deforestation-free livelihoods** — because a community that does can genuinely clean the chain, defend the remaining forest, and stop the frontier, while being honest that the forest is largely gone, the promises are often broken, and the just answer holds forest and farmer together.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact deforestation and its supply chain — and the leverage the community holds along that chain. Vague concern goes nowhere, and pitting forest against farmer fails; an effort aimed at "the clearing of this classified forest for cocoa, sold on by these traders to these chocolate companies bound by their promises and the import rules, which the monitoring can expose and which livelihoods could stop" is a real, workable effort — the kind Côte d'Ivoire's supply-chain levers can deliver. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

- 1. What forest is being lost?** This is the first question here. What **forest and wildlife** are being destroyed — the classified forest, the park, the endangered trees, the elephants and chimpanzees — by the cocoa frontier.
- 2. Whose cocoa is it — which buyers?** Which **traders and chocolate companies** buy the cocoa from the deforested area, since their commitments and the import rules are the sharpest supply-chain levers.
- 3. How do the import rules and monitoring apply?** How the **import regulation** barring deforestation-linked cocoa, and the **satellite and supply-chain monitoring**, can expose and exclude it.
- 4. How does the forest law apply?** How the **forest law, the classified-forest and park protections, and the reforestation policy** can defend the forest, and where the law is weak or wrongly applied.
- 5. What livelihoods can stop the clearing?** What **deforestation-free livelihoods** — agroforestry, fair prices, alternatives — can let the farmers live without clearing the forest, the deepest and most just lever.

A Worked Example

Suppose a classified forest is being cleared for cocoa, its beans sold on to major traders and chocolate companies, and the government threatens to evict the poor farmers.

Working the five questions: **what forest is lost? Whose cocoa is it? How do the import rules and monitoring apply? How does the forest law apply?** And what livelihoods can stop the clearing? The deciders and links are the farmers, the traders, the companies, the markets, and the forest authorities, with the buyers, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and livelihoods as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the forest falls to cocoa and nothing can be done" to a real effort: document the deforestation and trace its cocoa; press the buyers and the import regulators; use the monitoring and the forest law; and — decisively and justly — work to give the farmers deforestation-free livelihoods rather than mere eviction. That is a workable, just effort suited to Côte d'Ivoire — one that holds forest and farmer together. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a harm of this commodity-driven character: they trace the destruction along its whole length, from the poor farmer at the frontier to the wealthy consumer at the far end, and identify at each point the lever that fits. The forest loss becomes documentable harm; the cocoa becomes a traceable flow to named and pressable buyers; the import rules and monitoring become concrete tools to close the market to the tainted product; the forest law becomes a domestic defence; and the livelihoods question becomes the just and durable solution at the source. This full-chain view — refusing to stop at the visible clearer and instead following the harm to those with the power and the money to change it, while holding the farmer as a partner to be helped — is the first and most important thing an Ivorian effort does, because it converts a seemingly hopeless local loss into a set of specific, pressable points spread across a global supply chain, several of them far more vulnerable than the frontier itself.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the case must persuade buyers, import regulators, forest authorities, and the public, sound evidence of both the deforestation and its supply chain is decisive. A chocolate company, an import regulator, a certifier, and a journalist all move on evidence — and in Côte d'Ivoire, a clear record of the forest lost, the cocoa's path to its buyers, and the livelihoods that could stop the clearing is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Deforestation, the Chain, and the Deciders

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **deforestation** — the forest cleared, the location, whether it is a classified forest or a park — and, crucially here, trace the **cocoa's path**: the farmers, the local buyers, the **traders and chocolate companies** it flows to, since the supply chain is the distinctive lever. Establish the deciders and the chain precisely, because in Côte d'Ivoire the harm can be pressed at the buyers and the import rules only if the cocoa is traced from the deforested forest to the companies that sell it to the world.

Layer 2: The Loss — Forest, Wildlife, and Watershed

Document what is lost. Establish the **environmental harm** — the forest cleared, the endangered trees felled, the elephants and chimpanzees and biodiversity lost, the watersheds and soils degraded — drawing on **satellite monitoring, supply-chain mapping, conservation studies, and local knowledge**, much of which exists for a frontier as watched as Côte d'Ivoire's. And establish the **human dimension** — the farmers who clear, their poverty, and the harm that mere eviction would do them. Photographs, satellite data, and field documentation make the loss undeniable, and the supply-chain trace makes it actionable.

Layer 3: The Loss, the Chain, the Law, the Livelihoods, and the Justice

Finally, document the case and the just answer. Does the **environmental harm** show a real loss of forest and wildlife? Whose **cocoa** is it — traced to which buyers? How does the **import regulation and the forest law** apply? What **deforestation-free livelihoods** could stop the clearing? And, always, **how is justice held** — the forest defended without abandoning the poor farmers? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that can be pressed along the chain and grounded in justice. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented loss, a traced chain, an applicable law, a livelihoods answer, and a just holding of forest and farmer are exactly what let an Ivorian community defend the forest without punishing the poor. Build it well, and the buyers, the import rules, the forest law, and livelihoods become the community's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: the supply-chain trace is the part of the file that most distinguishes an Ivorian effort and most repays careful work, because it is what converts a local forest loss that the world would never notice into a liability for a company the world can see. A cleared forest, on its own, is a tragedy the market can ignore; the same cleared forest, traced through the local buyers and cooperatives to a named trader and a named chocolate company that has publicly promised zero deforestation and must satisfy the import rules, becomes that company's problem — a breach of its word and a legal risk it must answer for. Building this trace takes real work: identifying the cooperatives and buyers that purchase cocoa from the deforested area, following the beans up the chain to the exporters and manufacturers, and matching the flow to the companies' commitments and the import requirements. But it is precisely this trace, more than any other element, that gives an Ivorian community leverage over actors far more powerful than itself, and it is worth the effort to establish it as rigorously as the evidence allows.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in an Ivorian effort, and how to get it — with the **deforestation**, the **supply chain**, the **law**, the **livelihoods**, and the **justice** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Deforestation and Chain Record

Start with the harm and its chain. **Satellite deforestation alerts, supply-chain maps, and cooperative and buyer records** establish where the forest is being cleared and where its cocoa goes; much of this exists in the monitoring platforms and supply-chain mapping that track Ivorian cocoa, and is reachable. Trace the **cocoa's path** from the deforested area through the local buyers to the **traders and chocolate companies**, since that trace is the distinctive lever. Establish exactly **what forest is lost and whose cocoa it is**, because the buyers and the import rules can be engaged only on a traced chain.

The Forest, Wildlife, and Watershed Evidence

This is the heart of the environmental file. Gather the **environmental evidence** — the forest cleared, the endangered trees felled, the wildlife lost, the watersheds harmed — drawing on **satellite monitoring, conservation and biodiversity studies, and field surveys**, much of which exists for Côte d'Ivoire's watched forests and parks. And gather the **human evidence** — the farmers at the frontier, their poverty, and the effects of enforcement on them. Photographs, satellite imagery, and field documentation make the loss vivid and credible, and ground the case in reality.

The Supply-Chain and Regulation Record

Document the chain and the rules, because these are the distinctive Ivorian levers. Gather the **buyers' zero-deforestation commitments** and the assessments of whether they are honoured; the **import regulation** barring deforestation-linked cocoa and its due-diligence and traceability requirements; and the **certification and monitoring** that trace and verify. A community that can show deforestation, trace its cocoa to a company that has promised zero deforestation or that must meet import rules, holds a genuinely powerful lever the whole chain must answer.

The Law, Livelihoods, and Justice Record

Document the law, the livelihoods, and the justice. Gather the **forest law, the classified-forest and park protections, and the reforestation policy**, and how they apply — and where, as with concessions in protected forests, the law itself may be contested. Gather the **livelihoods options** — agroforestry, fair prices, alternative income — that could stop the clearing, and the programmes and funding that could support them. And gather the **human-rights dimension** — the treatment of farmers, the risk of unjust eviction — so the effort defends the forest without harming the poor. A community that holds forest, law, livelihoods, and justice together holds the whole of the Ivorian problem.

The People and the Community

Finally, map the human terrain. Who is affected — the forest communities, the wildlife, the farmers, the future? Who are the allies — the **conservation and supply-chain watchdogs, the certifiers, the sympathetic buyers, the livelihoods programmes, the forest agency's better elements**? And how are the **farmers engaged as partners, not enemies**, so the effort holds forest and farmer together? An Ivorian effort is advanced through the community and its allies along the chain, and through partnership with the farmers — so map that coalition and those levers, holding forest and farmer together, deliberately.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself. A community — organised, informed, and holding forest and farmer together — is what turns evidence into action along the supply chain. And here, distinctively, the community's task is not to oppose the farmers who clear the forest, who are often poor and driven by need, but to unite with them behind a way of living that does not require clearing — so that the defence of the forest and the wellbeing of the farmers become one cause.

Why the Community Is Decisive — and Must Hold Forest and Farmer Together

In Côte d'Ivoire, an organised community is decisive, but only if it holds forest and farmer together, because the farmers are not the enemy but part of the community and part of the solution. The community supplies what an effort runs on: the affected voices, the local and forest knowledge, the legitimacy, and — distinctively — the farmers whose choices determine the frontier. When a community unites forest-defenders and farmers behind deforestation-free livelihoods, and presses the buyers and the law together, it becomes a genuine force. **A united community here is not forest against farmer; it is forest and farmer together, seeking a way to live that keeps both — the only foundation on which an Ivorian effort can justly stand.** This is the hardest and most important reframing in the guide, and it deserves to be understood fully, because getting it wrong dooms an effort here. The instinctive shape of an environmental campaign is to identify who is destroying the forest and to stop them; but in Côte d'Ivoire the people destroying the forest are, very often, poor smallholder and migrant farmers with few other options, who clear forest not out of greed but because virgin soil grows the best cocoa and because the prices they receive leave them little margin to do otherwise. To treat them as the enemy is not only unjust but self-defeating: eviction and punishment simply push desperate people to clear forest elsewhere, and turn the very people whose choices determine the frontier into opponents of the effort. The community that understands this reorients entirely — it seeks to win the farmers over by offering them a better way to live, deforestation-free, so that the people who would otherwise clear the forest become instead its defenders. Forest and farmer together is not a slogan but the only structure in which the Ivorian problem can actually be solved.

Finding the Affected Community

Begin with those the harm touches most — the **forest communities, those who depend on the watershed and the wildlife, and the farmers at the frontier** whose choices and whose poverty drive the clearing. Widen to all who depend on the forests, the rivers, and a liveable climate. Name the shared stake — **our forests, our wildlife, our water, and a decent living for our farmers** — because in a country where the forest is nearly gone and the farmers are poor, the cause that unites is the one that saves both the forest and the people. There is a real power in this dual framing, because it turns a conflict into a common project and so widens the circle of those who will support it. A cause framed narrowly as saving the forest may find the farmers indifferent or hostile, since it seems to threaten their livelihood; a cause framed as blaming the farmers may find the wider community reluctant to turn on its own poor. But a cause framed as saving both the forest and the farmers — protecting the wildlife and the watershed while securing a decent, deforestation-free living for the people who work the land — invites everyone in, because it asks no one to sacrifice their neighbour or their living. In a country still healing from conflict and wary of divisions, a cause that unites rather than divides is not only more just but far more likely to hold together and endure.

Coalition-Building Along the Chain

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Côte d'Ivoire the coalition spans the chain and the fields. Reach to the **conservation and supply-chain watchdogs** that track cocoa and forests; the **certifiers and monitoring platforms**; the **sympathetic buyers and the livelihoods programmes**; the **forest agency's better elements**; and, above all, the **farmers and their cooperatives**, as partners in deforestation-free farming. Frame the coalition around a shared defence of the forest and a decent living for farmers, uniting conservation and livelihood. Breadth here means joining forest-defenders, farmers, watchdogs, and buyers into one cause.

Sustaining the Effort

Ivorian efforts can be sustained through the tangible work of livelihoods and forest defence. Keep the community **informed, united, and holding forest and farmer together**; mark real steps — a livelihoods project launched, a buyer pressed, deforestation-linked cocoa excluded, a forest defended, agroforestry taking root. And keep the effort grounded in livelihoods and justice, because an effort that turns forest against farmer will fracture the community and fail. The effort that lasts is the one that stays united behind deforestation-free livelihoods, presses the chain and the law, and holds the forest and the farmers together. Sustaining such an effort is helped, in Côte d'Ivoire, by the tangible progress that livelihoods work provides, which gives a community renewable proof that its labour is bearing fruit — a cooperative earning better prices, an agroforestry plot yielding both cocoa and shade trees, a stretch of frontier that has stopped advancing because the farmers beside it no longer need to clear. These concrete gains renew a community's energy and draw in more farmers, in a virtuous cycle, in a way that the slower and more distant supply-chain and legal work cannot on its own. The discipline is to keep the livelihoods work at the heart of the effort, as the visible, unifying anchor, while the pressure on the buyers, the import regulators, and the forest authorities advances alongside it — so that the community always has, in its own farmers' improving lives and its own held frontier, a living proof that saving the forest and lifting the farmers are one and the same work.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & SUPPLY-CHAIN CHALLENGES — THE FOREST LAW, THE IMPORT REGULATION, AND THE BUYERS' COMMITMENTS

This is where an Ivorian effort is realistically advanced — not by pitting forest against farmer, but through the **forest law, the import regulation, and the buyers' commitments** that a globally-traded commodity answers to, grounded in deforestation-free livelihoods. Here the legal, regulatory, and supply-chain levers come together, because in Côte d'Ivoire a harm sold to the world is pressed back through the world's markets, its laws, and its buyers.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but bounded and slow**. The forest law is **real but imperfectly enforced**, and some of its provisions are contested; the import regulation is **powerful but new and still being implemented**; and the buyers' commitments are **real but often unkept**, requiring pressure and verification. What these levers realistically achieve is **deforestation-linked cocoa excluded, buyers pressed to clean their chains, forests defended, and the frontier slowed by livelihoods** — real outcomes, if not a dramatic reversal of a largely-lost forest. Enter this front clear-eyed and just: the forest law, the import rules, and the buyers are Côte d'Ivoire's distinctive levers, strongest when the **deforestation is proven, the chain is traced, and livelihoods are offered** — but the forest is largely gone, the promises are often broken, and the farmers must not be abandoned.

The Buyers and Their Commitments

The first and most distinctive front is the buyers. The **traders and chocolate companies** that buy Ivorian cocoa have made **zero-deforestation commitments**, and are increasingly ranked and scored on whether they honour them. Document the deforestation, trace the cocoa to a company, and hold it to its own promise: expose the gap between commitment and conduct, press the company to clean its chain, exclude the deforested cocoa, and fund livelihoods. The certifiers, the supply-chain scorecards, and the watchdogs are allies here, since a company shown to buy deforestation-linked cocoa against its own pledge faces real reputational and commercial pressure. This front reaches the whole chain through the companies that carry the cocoa to the world. A practical caution is worth adding here about how to press the buyers effectively, because the approach matters. A company confronted with credible, specific evidence that its own cocoa is linked to a documented deforestation, in breach of its public promise and its legal obligations, has strong reasons to respond — reputational, commercial, and legal; but a company faced with vague or unproven accusations can easily deflect, and a company treated purely as an enemy may simply cut ties with the region, harming the very farmers the effort seeks to help. The most effective approach is therefore both firm and constructive: firm in presenting the traced evidence and demanding that the company clean its chain and honour its commitments, but constructive in offering a path — funding deforestation-free livelihoods, supporting traceability, rewarding clean farmers — by which the company can meet its obligations while keeping and improving its sourcing. A buyer given both a credible problem and a workable path to solve it is far more likely to become part of the solution than one simply denounced.

The Import Regulation

The second and powerful front is the import regulation. The **new rules barring deforestation-linked cocoa from wealthy markets** require importers to prove, through due diligence and traceability, that their cocoa is not linked to deforestation — or face exclusion and fines. This is a growing, powerful lever on the entire chain, because it makes deforestation a commercial liability all the way to the source. Document the deforestation and its chain, and bring it to the **import regulators and the due-diligence systems**, so that deforestation-linked cocoa is excluded and the whole chain is pushed toward traceable, deforestation-free sourcing. This regulation is the newest and among the strongest of the Ivorian levers. It is worth understanding why this import regulation is so distinctively powerful, because it changes the incentives all the way down the chain. Before such rules, a trader or manufacturer could buy the cheapest cocoa available and leave the question of its forest origins to others; the market rewarded low prices, not clean sourcing, and so deforestation carried no commercial penalty. An import rule that bars deforestation-linked cocoa from a large, wealthy market reverses that logic: suddenly a company's access to its most valuable customers depends on being able to prove its cocoa is deforestation-free, which means it must trace its supply chain to the farm, exclude the tainted product, and reward the clean. This pushes the whole chain — traders, exporters, cooperatives, and ultimately farmers — toward traceability and deforestation-free production, and it does so through the companies' own commercial self-interest rather than through the goodwill of their promises. For a community, this means the import rule is a lever that works even on companies that would ignore a mere appeal, and it is worth learning its requirements well enough to invoke them precisely.

The Forest Law, Governance, and Livelihoods

The third front is the domestic law and the just foundation. The **forest law, the classified forests and parks, and the reforestation policy** are real domestic levers — use them to defend a forest, challenge an unlawful clearing, or contest a concession, while pressing for the law's better enforcement and questioning provisions that harm forest communities. But the deepest lever, and the just one, is **deforestation-free livelihoods**: agroforestry, fair farmgate prices, and alternative income that let farmers live without clearing

the forest. Press the buyers, the import systems, the reforestation policy, and the international partners to fund these livelihoods, because only a farmer who can thrive without clearing will stop the frontier. Pursued together — the buyers, the import rules, the forest law, and livelihoods — these fronts are how an Ivorian community defends the forest justly, holding forest and farmer together. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so powerfully in Côte d'Ivoire's particular situation. The buyers' commitments and the import rules supply the pressure that reaches the whole chain — because they make deforestation a commercial liability all the way to the source, they can move the entire market toward deforestation-free sourcing in a way no single forest fight could. The monitoring supplies the evidence that makes that pressure credible and specific, tracing a particular clearing to a particular buyer. The forest law supplies the domestic authority to defend a particular forest. And livelihoods supply the only durable solution — the reason the farmers will actually stop clearing. Each alone is limited: the buyers may drag their feet, the import rules are new, the forest law is patchily enforced, and livelihoods take time to build. But woven together — the deforestation traced and exposed, the buyer pressed by its own promise and the law, the import market closed to the tainted cocoa, the forest defended, and the farmers given a better way to live — they form a system of pressure and solution that can genuinely clean the chain and stop the frontier, in a way that reaches from a single Ivorian forest all the way to the world's chocolate shelves and back.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of deforestation, supply chain, and livelihoods becomes different arguments for a buyer, an import regulator, the forest authorities, and the public. Translate deliberately, and always holding forest and farmer together.

For the Buyers and Chocolate Companies

Buyers respond to **their commitments, their reputations, and now the law**. Frame the deforestation as a breach of the company's own zero-deforestation promise and a liability under the import rules: here is the cleared forest, here is your cocoa flowing from it, here is your broken pledge and your legal exposure. Give them the traced chain and the remedy — exclude the deforested cocoa, clean the chain, fund livelihoods. Make it concrete: *here is your promise, here is the deforestation, here is your cocoa*. This is the argument that reaches the whole chain.

For the Import Regulators

Import regulators respond to **the traceability and due-diligence rules**. Frame the deforestation as exactly what the rules bar: cocoa linked to forest destruction entering a regulated market against the law. Give them the documented chain and ask that the deforestation-linked cocoa be excluded and the importer's due diligence scrutinised. The import rules are strongest when fed precise, traced evidence of deforestation reaching the market.

For the Forest Authorities

The forest authorities respond to **the forest law and the reforestation goals**. Frame the harm as a breach of the classified-forest or park protections, or a failure of the reforestation policy, and seek defence of the forest — but pair it always with the call for livelihoods, so the response is not merely eviction. Give the authorities the documented breach and the just remedy, and press for better enforcement and for the farmers to be given alternatives, not just expelled.

For the Public, the Consumers, and the World

The public and consumers respond to **a clear story of forest, wildlife, and chocolate**; the world to **a striking case of commodity-driven destruction**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: the forests and elephants of Côte d'Ivoire falling for the chocolate on the world's shelves, and a community fighting to save both the forest and its farmers. Frame it as a shared responsibility of producers, companies, and consumers. Keep it accurate; credibility is quickly tested. And frame the farmers with dignity, as people to be helped, not blamed.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, and never turn forest against farmer. Your credibility is your greatest asset, and it is quickly tested. State the deforestation precisely, trace the chain accurately, and hold forest and farmer together, offering livelihoods alongside every demand. Frame the farmers with dignity and the companies factually. A community that is precise, credible, and just — defending the forest while lifting the farmers — is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches or scapegoats the poor.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, distinctively, the story reaches all the way to the world's consumers, whose chocolate is made from the cocoa that clears the forest. The story — the forests and elephants of Côte d'Ivoire falling for the world's chocolate, and a community fighting to save both forest and farmer — is one that moves a nation, a market, and a global public.

Why Media Matters

The buyers, the regulators, the government, and the consumers behave differently when the harm is visible and traced. Media does three things here: it **informs and unites the community and the public**, it **raises the reputational and commercial cost** to the buyers and the market, and it **connects the destruction to the chocolate** the world consumes, making it a shared responsibility. Because the cocoa is sold to a watching world, consumer and market attention is a genuine, powerful lever here, as it is not for a purely domestic harm. And the story of vanishing forests and wildlife behind the world's chocolate is one that resonates globally. This global resonance is a genuine and usable asset, and worth cultivating with care. Chocolate is a beloved, everyday product in the wealthy markets that consume Ivorian cocoa, and most of the people who enjoy it have no idea that the forests and elephants of West Africa are falling to produce it; a story that reveals this hidden connection has a power that a distant, abstract deforestation story lacks, because it implicates the consumer's own pleasure and choice. Told well and accurately, such a story can move consumers to ask questions of the brands they buy, move brands to protect their reputations by cleaning their chains, and move regulators to enforce the import rules — a chain of pressure that runs from a chocolate bar back to an Ivorian forest. But it must be told with care and accuracy, and always with the farmers held in dignity rather than shamed, so that the consumer's response is to demand a better chain, not to abandon Ivorian cocoa and the farmers who depend on it.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the forest, the wildlife, and the chocolate, and with the farmers held in dignity. The strongest frame is concrete and connecting: *the forests and elephants of Côte d'Ivoire are falling to grow the cocoa in the world's chocolate — and a community is fighting to save the forest and give its farmers a decent living without clearing it*. Put the forest and the connection to consumers first, and the livelihoods and justice close behind, because that connection engages the market and the just frame keeps the farmers on side. Keep it

scrupulously accurate; overstatement is quickly caught. The Ivorian story is powerful because it links a beloved product to a real loss, and because it holds forest and farmer together.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience. **Local radio and community networks** for the communities and the farmers; the **national media** for the public and the forest authorities; the **international conservation, consumer, and news media** for the buyers, the regulators, and the global public; and the **supply-chain and certification platforms** for the market. Because Côte d'Ivoire's harm answers to buyers, regulators, and consumers as much as to the state, the international and market channels matter greatly — the connection to the world's chocolate is the story's distinctive power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, just, and constructive — the goal is a cleaned chain, a defended forest, and a sustained farmer, not a story that scapegoats the poor or exaggerates. Hold forest and farmer together in every telling, and frame the farmers with dignity. Handle the companies and the government factually, and mind the sensitive politics of land and belonging in a country marked by past conflict. And sustain the story through the tangible work of livelihoods and forest defence. Above all, let the connection between the world's chocolate and the vanishing forest, and the fight to save both forest and farmer, carry the story, because that is where an Ivorian effort is strongest and most just.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real deforestation, the real chain, and the real livelihoods, keep it factual, and hold forest and farmer together. Here a traced chain, and justice, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — deforestation and cocoa sourcing at [location]

Dear [official / department],

I am writing on behalf of [community] regarding the deforestation of [classified forest / park] at [location] for cocoa. To understand and respond to this harm, we request the **relevant forest and land records**, information on the **sourcing and buyers of cocoa from this area**, and the **reforestation and livelihoods programmes** that may apply. We wish to defend our forest while supporting the farmers who depend on it.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Letter to a Cocoa Buyer or Chocolate Company

Subject: Deforestation-linked cocoa in your supply chain from [location]

To [trader / chocolate company],

We write regarding cocoa sourced from [location] in Côte d'Ivoire, where [classified forest / park] is being cleared for cocoa — cocoa that appears to enter your supply chain, contrary to your zero-deforestation commitment and to the import rules you must meet. We respectfully urge you to trace and exclude this

deforestation-linked cocoa, to clean your chain, and to fund deforestation-free livelihoods for the affected farmers. We attach documentation of the deforestation and its chain.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: Alert to an Import Regulator

Subject: Deforestation-linked cocoa entering the market from [location]

To the [import regulator / due-diligence authority],

We submit evidence that cocoa linked to the deforestation of [classified forest / park] at [location] in Côte d'Ivoire is entering [market] through [importer / company], contrary to the deforestation-free import rules. We respectfully request that this cocoa be scrutinised and excluded, and the importer's due diligence examined. We attach documentation of the deforestation and the traced supply chain.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Letter to a Conservation or Supply-Chain Watchdog

Subject: Partnership on deforestation at [location]

Dear [organisation],

Our community faces the clearing of [forest] for cocoa at [location], sold on to [buyers]. We seek your partnership — your monitoring, your supply-chain tracing, and your voice — to expose the deforestation, trace it to its buyers, and hold them to account, while supporting the farmers with livelihoods. May we work together?

With respect,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Media Pitch

Subject: The forests and elephants behind the world's chocolate at [location]

Dear [journalist],

At [location] in Côte d'Ivoire, [forest / park] and its wildlife are being cleared to grow the cocoa in the world's chocolate, its beans flowing to [buyers] — and a community is fighting to save both the forest and its poor farmers. There is a powerful story here linking chocolate to forest loss, and a just fight to save both forest and farmer, and we can provide the evidence, the traced chain, and community voices.

Sincerely,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Letter to the Forest Authorities

Subject: Defending [forest] while supporting its farmers

Dear [forest agency],

We write regarding the clearing of [classified forest / park] at [location] for cocoa. We ask that the forest's protection be enforced and its reforestation supported — but we also ask, urgently, that the farmers who clear it out of poverty be given deforestation-free livelihoods rather than mere eviction, so that the forest is defended justly and the farmers are not simply cast out. We can provide documentation and welcome dialogue.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Letter Proposing Livelihoods

Subject: Deforestation-free livelihoods for our farmers at [location]

Dear [buyer / programme / partner],

The clearing of [forest] at [location] is driven by the poverty of farmers who need fertile land and fair income. We believe the answer is **deforestation-free livelihoods** — agroforestry, fair prices, and alternatives — that let farmers thrive without clearing the forest. We ask your partnership and funding to build these livelihoods, so that saving the forest and supporting the farmers become one and the same work.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our forest, our wildlife, our farmers — let us save them together

Dear neighbours,

The forest is falling for cocoa, our wildlife with it — but the farmers who clear it are our own people, poor and in need. Together, we can save both: by pressing the companies and the markets that buy our cocoa, defending our forest through the law, and building livelihoods that let our farmers thrive without clearing. Please join us: come to [gathering], share what you know, and add your voice. Let us save our forest and our farmers together.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes clearing is moving fast — a forest being felled, a park invaded, a harvest about to ship — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest here, which means the buyers, the monitoring, and an import alert.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what forest is being cleared, and whose cocoa it becomes**. Identify the immediate pressure point — a **shipment, a buyer, a felling, a harvest** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **supply-chain watchdogs and the monitoring platforms** at once, because in Côte d'Ivoire tracing the cocoa to its buyers is the fastest route to real leverage — and begin engaging the **farmers as partners**, not enemies.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **A traced chain to a named buyer** puts immediate pressure on a company bound by its promise and the law. **An import alert** can flag deforestation-linked cocoa to the market fast. **Satellite monitoring** can document a fresh clearing at once. **A watchdog's exposure** can reach the buyers and consumers quickly. These outpace the slower work of livelihoods and forest litigation — which must follow — because the supply chain reacts fast to exposure.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the watchdogs and the buyers fast, and engage the farmers. Reach immediately to the **supply-chain and conservation watchdogs, the monitoring platforms, the sympathetic buyers, and the farmers themselves**. A community tracing a fresh clearing to a named buyer and alerting the market, while engaging the farmers as partners, is the most a rapid Ivorian effort can do — and it can move a company fast. Speed favours the prepared: know the clearing, the chain, and your allies before the shipment ships.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted by poverty, by broken corporate promises, by weak enforcement, and by sensitive politics. This is Côte d'Ivoire's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the field is level, or that the forest can be saved by blaming the poor, would be false.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **Poverty drives the clearing** — farmers clear forest because virgin soil grows the best cocoa and low prices push them to expand. **Corporate promises go unkept** — the companies pledge zero deforestation but too often fail to deliver. **Enforcement is weak or unjust** — the forest law is patchily enforced, and where it is enforced it has sometimes meant evicting the poor. **The politics are sensitive** — land and belonging are fraught in a country marked by past conflict. This is not a level field, and an effort here must be built to clean the chain, fund livelihoods, and hold forest and farmer together, not to punish the poor.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers that reach the chain and the ones that address the poverty. Lean on the **import rules and the buyers' commitments** that make deforestation a commercial liability; the **monitoring** that exposes and traces; the **forest law** where it can justly defend; and above all **deforestation-free livelihoods** that address the poverty driving the clearing. Hold **forest and farmer together**, because an effort that turns them against each other will fracture and fail. And build the record and the livelihoods even where progress is slow, because a cleaned chain and a sustained farmer accumulate into a defended forest over time. A tilted field here is worked by cleaning the chain and lifting the farmers, not by blaming them. This is the strategic heart of an Ivorian effort, and it distinguishes it sharply from the fights in most other countries in this series. In many places the destroyer of the environment is a powerful company or a repressive state, to be pressured, exposed, or resisted; here the immediate destroyer is often a poor farmer, and the powerful actors — the traders, the chocolate companies, the wealthy consumer markets — sit far away at the other end of a supply chain. This inversion changes everything: the effort's pressure should fall not on the poor farmer at the frontier but on the powerful actors down the chain who profit from and can change the whole system, while the farmer is offered help rather

than blame. Directing pressure down the chain to those with power and money, and offering partnership up the chain to those with need, is the distinctive logic of a just Ivorian effort — the opposite of the instinct to stop the visible clearer, and far more effective.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may lose — a forest may fall, a park may be invaded, the frontier may move on — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; much of the forest is already gone, and the poverty and the broken promises are real. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **deforestation was documented, the chain traced, buyers pressed, livelihoods built, and the next effort starts stronger** — and every farmer given a deforestation-free living, and every buyer made to clean its chain, protects the forest that remains. Fight to save this forest; if it falls, the livelihoods you build, the chain you clean, and the pressure you apply will defend the next, because on a frontier this advanced, the real victory is stopping it from moving further and saving what remains. There is a hard realism in this that is worth stating plainly, because it is true and because it keeps an effort from despair. On a frontier where the great majority of the forest is already gone, no effort can restore what half a century of clearing has destroyed, and some of what remains will still be lost before the frontier is finally halted. But the remaining forests and parks — the last refuges of the elephants and chimpanzees, the last stretches of intact watershed — are precisely what is still worth fighting for, and they can be saved, if the chain is cleaned and the frontier is stopped. And every farmer given a deforestation-free living is a farmer who will not clear the next patch, so that the work of livelihoods, once begun, keeps protecting the forest that remains long after any single campaign. In this fight, more than most, the honest measure of success is not the forest restored but the frontier halted and the last forests held — and that measure a determined, just community can genuinely meet.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Côte d'Ivoire, the cocoa and timber trades carry real risks of corruption and capture — shadowy financiers fund illegal loggers, the forest agency has been found wanting in its oversight, and illicit networks produce far more timber than licensed traders. This must be approached with care, and the safer, more effective route runs through the supply chain, the monitoring, and the international channels.

Telling Capture from the Ordinary Tilt

Poverty-driven clearing and weak enforcement are the ordinary tilt; where officials, financiers, and traders profit from illegal logging and turn a blind eye to deforestation, that is capture. The marks of capture are sharper: **shadowy financiers behind illegal logging, an oversight agency that logs beyond its licences or fails to sanction, illicit timber networks dwarfing the legal trade, and buyers who knowingly take deforestation-linked cocoa**. Be rigorous and careful: **distinguish the ordinary poverty-driven tilt from provable corruption**, and do not level accusations the evidence does not support, especially amid sensitive politics. The supply-chain monitoring, the certification systems, the import regulators, and international investigative bodies are the safer tools, because they can pursue through market and legal channels what is risky to pursue directly at home.

Responding to Capture — Carefully

Where capture is real, the response runs through the chain and the market. Use the **import rules and the buyers' due diligence**, which make knowingly sourcing deforestation-linked or illegally-logged cocoa a liability. Take evidence to the **supply-chain watchdogs, the certifiers, and international investigative and transparency bodies**, which can pursue from beyond the reach of local capture. Use the **monitoring**

that traces illegal timber and cocoa. Document meticulously and protect sources, because the illicit networks can be dangerous. Route the exposure through the market, the regulators, and the international channels — not through risky direct confrontation with illicit networks.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note governs everything here. Côte d'Ivoire is a functioning if imperfect democracy, not a police state, but its cocoa and timber frontiers involve real money, illicit networks, and sensitive politics, so pursue this work with care. Favour the **supply-chain, monitoring, import, and livelihoods levers** over risky confrontation with loggers or officials. Protect those who document illegal logging, which can be dangerous. Hold **forest and farmer together**, and treat the poor farmers as partners, never as the enemy. And mind the sensitive politics of land and belonging. Care here means favouring the market and monitoring levers, protecting those who document, and defending the forest justly — because no forest saved is worth a person harmed, and because the real work of cleaning the chain and lifting the farmers can be done through the levers that do not require dangerous confrontation.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single, just effort against deforestation in Côte d'Ivoire.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the deforestation-chain-and-livelihoods file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition** unites the community, holding forest and farmer together. **Legal, regulatory, and supply-chain** work presses the buyers, the import rules, and the forest law. **Media** connects the harm to the world's chocolate. The deforestation, the chain, and the livelihoods feed all five at once — a documented clearing is a case for a buyer, an alert for an import regulator, a matter for the forest law, and a story for consumers together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, spanning the forest, the chain, and the market, they compound all the way to the world's consumers.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the deforestation, trace its chain, and identify the buyers, the import routes, the forest-law avenues, and the livelihoods options; begin documentation and engage the farmers. **Middle (months 2–18):** press the buyers and the import regulators; use the monitoring and the forest law; and begin building deforestation-free livelihoods with buyers, programmes, and partners. **Later (months and years):** secure cleaned supply chains, defended forests, and — above all — livelihoods that stop the frontier, and keep holding forest and farmer together whatever the pace. An Ivorian effort is patient, and its deepest work — livelihoods — is long; pace it accordingly, and hold forest and farmer together throughout.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the deforestation and trace its cocoa; press the buyers and the import rules; use the monitoring and the forest law; build deforestation-free livelihoods; and hold forest and farmer together in everything.** The community that presses all five, spanning the forest, the supply chain, and the market, and defending the forest while lifting its farmers, is the one that can genuinely clean the chain, defend the remaining forest, and stop the frontier

— the only kind of victory a largely-cleared, poverty-driven frontier allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposing deforestation in Côte d'Ivoire is genuinely difficult, and bound up with poverty, broken promises, and a largely-lost forest, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: there is no landmark victory, much of the forest is gone, and the clearing is driven by the poor. And yet the effort is not futile, because Côte d'Ivoire's destruction is a commodity sold to a watching world, and the levers that reach it — the buyers bound by their promises and the law, the import rules, the monitoring, the forest law, and deforestation-free livelihoods — are real, and growing, and can defend the forest that remains while lifting the farmers.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **Deforestation-free livelihoods are the deepest and most just lever, the only thing that truly stops the frontier. The supply chain — the buyers and the import rules — is the distinctive lever, reaching the whole chain through the world's chocolate. The monitoring exposes and traces, and the forest law defends where it can. But the forest is largely gone, the promises are often broken, and the farmers must never be abandoned.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive, market-spanning levers, and the honest weight of poverty, broken promises, and a lost forest.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the justice — that give these efforts their force. Document the deforestation and trace its cocoa. Press the buyers and the import rules. Use the monitoring and the forest law. Build deforestation-free livelihoods. And hold forest and farmer together in everything — because in a country where the poor both clear the forest and suffer for it, an effort that defends the forest while lifting the farmers is the only one that is both effective and just.

The forests of Côte d'Ivoire are nearly gone — the great majority cleared in half a century, the elephants and chimpanzees vanishing, the classified forests and parks invaded, much of it to grow the cocoa that becomes the world's chocolate — and this guide has hidden none of it, nor pretended the poor farmers who clear it are villains rather than people in need; there is no landmark victory here to promise you. But the very fact that this destruction is sold to the world is its vulnerability: the companies that buy the cocoa are bound by their own promises and by new laws, the import rules can bar deforestation-linked cocoa from wealthy markets, the satellites and supply-chain maps can trace the harm to its buyers, and the farmers can be given a way to live without clearing the forest. There is no easy victory, and no landmark precedent to inherit; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted on holding forest and farmer together. But your forests, your wildlife, your rivers, and the dignity of your farmers are worth defending, the levers running through the world's chocolate are real, and the patient, just work of cleaning the chain, defending the forest, and lifting the farmers is one your community can genuinely do — and save both the forest that remains and the people who live from it. So can you.